

FLINTLOCK PISTOLS (1776–1800)

In the late 18th century, flintlock firearms achieved a state of technical perfection and elegance that would last until the flintlock gave way to percussion weapons in the 19th century. Certain styles became popular, such as the “Queen Anne” pistol in UK, with its characteristic “cannon” barrel. Refinements in the flintlock mechanism were relatively few, but included a variant called the box-lock mechanism, in which the cock was placed centrally within the pistol, making the gun easier to carry.



▲ RAPPAHANNOCK PISTOL

Date c.1776

Origin US

Barrel 9in (23cm)

Caliber .69in (17.5mm)

At the Rappahannock Forge near Falmouth, Virginia, Scottish émigré James Hunter produced the first American-manufactured military pistol. It was a copy of the British Light Dragoon pistol and was used by the Light Dragoons in the Continental Army.

Painted decoration

► FOUR-BARRELED TAP-ACTION PISTOL

Date 1780

Origin UK

Barrel 2½in (6.35cm)

Caliber .38in (9.6mm)

A revolver is a gun with a number of chambers—each carrying a round—in a revolving cylinder. An alternative to this system was to multiply the number of barrels. Two barrels, each with its own lock, were quite common, and four—and even six—became feasible with the invention of the tap (see p.45). The taps, one for each vertical pair, presented priming for each of the two lower barrels when turned.



▲ QUEEN ANNE PISTOL

Date 1775

Origin UK

Barrel 4½in (11.7cm)

Caliber .46in (11.7mm)

The distinctive form of the Queen Anne pistol continued long after the eponymous lady's death in 1714. The tapered “cannon” barrel screwed into a standing breech, in which the lock plate, trigger plate, and butt strap were forged in one piece. This double-barreled example is by Griffin and Tow.



▲ FRENCH MODÈLE 1777 PISTOL

Date 1782

Origin France

Barrel 8½in (21.5cm)

Caliber .69in (17.5mm)

French military firearms were well constructed. This cavalry pistol has a lock mechanism built within a brass body and it lacks a forestock. Its ramrod passes through the lock body and into the wooden butt.

